



# The future of online education

A resistance to change is the primary hurdle in the way of online education reaching its full potential in India

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No other Internet application has received as much attention as the use of the Net for education. Online education is more than just online content—it includes peer-to-peer and student-expert interactions, evaluation and assessment, and access to additional learning resources. Tomes have been written on the market potential of online education, with estimated figures varying from \$11 billion upwards.

Most education companies and universities are in the process of experimenting with a variety of business and instructional models—from the completely free online content that MIT

relationship between the faculty and students has been one of the most enduring ones from the dawn of civilization, and will not change in a hurry. At the student level, it remains, at best, a matter of curiosity and at worst, a fad.

## Where do we go from here?

In the context of the dot com world crashing all around us, belief in e-learning has so far weathered the downturn. E-learning has the potential to be the next killer application of the Net and in the words of John Chambers, CEO of Cisco, "...the scale of network traffic generated by e-learning, will make today's exchange of e-mail messages look like a rounding error". But in order to make this potential a reality, leaders of organisations and educators must spearhead a 'cultural revolution' to put technology-based learning in perspective. Most importantly, the use of the Net for education does not mean the end of the classroom.

Rather the classroom, the Net and the teacher will have to restructure their roles in the learning process. Such changes have happened before, but they take time. To take a very Indian analogy, in ancient India the only format of education was for the student to live with the master for many years.

Through this extended interaction it was believed that knowledge would pass on from master to pupil. Imagine the consternation of the guru if he were told that from the next year his students would come to the classroom (ashram) for a few hours a day only, and then return home. Yet this classroom method has been the only way that we, in our generation, have experienced education! A similar inflection point is now occurring as the Internet comes to play a greater role in our lives.

The future of learning is e-learning. This is true of all the segments: K-12, graduate education, corporate training and continuing education. As we move to a connected and networked world, the Internet will become the primary tool for learning, suitably supported by the classroom and faculty. ■

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plans to host to a lot of combinations of brick-and-mortar and Net-based systems.

Large Fortune-500 companies have all embarked on some form of online initiative, with a few setting up full-fledged virtual universities to impart training to their employees, partners and distributors. For the student there are now a host of graduate and post-graduate programs available on the Net, offered primarily by universities. Most schools in the US have some component of access to Internet resources as part of their education methodology.

In India, the cost effectiveness of online training, though accepted at the conceptual level by organisations, has not found many takers. Only a few progressive organisations are implementing some pilot programs. While technology/infrastructure is often cited as a reason for not implementing, the more deep-rooted issues are cultural acceptance and changes in mindsets. The rela-